

Gandhi called the untouchables of India *harijans* , which means “children of God.” He wished to treat them like any other Indians. But even members of the ashram, who agreed with most of Gandhi’s beliefs, did not always agree with Gandhi’s teachings about untouchables. In September 1915, an untouchable couple and their baby daughter wanted to join the ashram. Gandhi accepted them. Some members objected and left the ashram. Even Kasturbai was upset. She refused to work in the kitchen alongside the untouchable woman. The textile owners who had donated money for the running of the ashram refused to continue their support.

Then one day, one of the most powerful Hindu businessmen in Ahmedabad drove to the ashram. He gave Gandhi enough money to keep the community going for at least another year. Gandhi was pleased. The fact that traditional Hindus were willing to help his efforts at the ashram made Gandhi believe that change was coming soon. Kasturbai looked to Gandhi as her leader and stood by him.

Gandhi also cared for poor people in the villages that surrounded the ashram. He opened schools in the villages. He taught the peasants that good